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Prosecution Admits It Has No Case

DAWSON 5 MURDER CHARGES DROPPED

(Atlanta, Ga.) - Murder charges were dropped against the Dawson 5 this week when the prosecution finally admitted that it had no evidence.

The five young Black men — Roosevelt Watson, 21, Henderson Watson, 24, Johnny Jackson, 19, James Jackson, 18, and J.D. Davenport, 20 — had spent periods in jail ranging from nine to nineteen months while awaiting trial on the false charges. Since their arrest in 1975, a nationwide movement had been formed to protest this glaring example of "Southern justice."

The prosecution's decision to drop the case came one week after Terrell County Superior Court Judge Walker Geer suppressed a "confession" obtained from Roosevelt Watson, who was intimidated by Dawson police. Watson was accused of firing the shot that killed a White ranch foreman, Gordon "Bubba" Howell, during an alleged holdup of a grocery store in Dawson, Georgia, in January of 1976.

In his ruling Geer stated, "The evidence, taken as a whole, showed that the statements were not freely, voluntarily and intelligently



Dawson 5 defendants hold press conference following the Terrell County D.A.'s announcement that the false murder charges against them will be dismissed. The five young Black men endured nearly two years of coercion and terror.

made." During a preliminary hearing it was brought out in court that police had coerced Watson into confessing — while he was wired to a polygraph (lie detector) machine — with the threat that he would be electrocuted if he

didn't. Watson was also later threatened with castration if he didn't confess to Howell's murder.

In the hearings that were held last August, CONTINUED ON PAGE 10

Additional Funds For Education Neglected

CARTER REJECTS INCREASED URBAN AID

(Washington, D.C.) - Indications of a deep and growing rift between the White House and Department of Health, Education and Welfare (HEW) officials surfaced last week as President Carter announced his refusal to

commit additional urban aid funds to help depressed cities in the 1978 fiscal budget.

Inside sources at HEW told the *New York Times* and others that top officials in the Department were "livid" over White House

handling of a carefully prepared draft report proposing an expansion and "targeting" of a number of federal programs in the hopes of creating jobs and generating economic growth in neglected urban cities.

HEW officials criticized Carter's announcement of no additional funds last week as indicating that the President and his top advisers are unwilling to make the political and financial commitment that an effective national urban policy program would demand.

White House sources explained the refusal by blaming unnamed "experts in urban affairs" for not yet developing a satisfactory policy.

One staff member who was present at a meeting last week quoted Carter as complaining, "Don't tell me we'll spend more money all around and then we'll call it an urban policy. Give me something worth funding if you want more money."

On the other hand, other advisers indicated that the President does not want new programs but would rather make present efforts work more efficiently.

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Tenement dwellings like the one above will continue to exist in the U.S. due to the Carter administration's refusal to provide increased urban aid to rebuild our blighted inner cities.

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